

CANCER

CANCER IS NOT A SINGLE DISEASE, BUT A LARGE GROUP OF DISORDERS WITH DIFFERENT SYMPTOMS. NEARLY ALL CANCERS HAVE THE SAME BASIC CAUSE: CELLS MULTIPLY UNCONTROLLABLY BECAUSE THE NORMAL REGULATION OF THEIR DIVISION HAS BEEN DAMAGED.

CANCEROUS (MALIGNANT) TUMOURS

A cancerous (malignant) tumour is a mass of abnormal cells that divide excessively quickly and do not carry out the normal functions of their tissue. These cells are often irregular in size and shape, and bear little resemblance to the normal

cells from which they arose. This irregular appearance is often used to diagnose cancer during microscopic examination of a small sample of tissue taken from a tumour. The tumour gradually enlarges, crowding out normal cells, pressing on nerves, and infiltrating blood and lymph vessels. It is important to distinguish a malignant tumour from a non-malignant one, because cancerous cells can spread to other parts of the body.

MALIGNANT TUMOUR GROWTH

A cancerous tumour grows and spreads by forcing its way between other cells and infiltrating the tissues, eventually interfering with their function.

